CHAMPION SPIRIT

A resurgent Virat Kohli unseats M.S. Dhoni from the top in a cricket-heavy list. P.V. Sindhu and Mithali Raj retain their ranks

By **SUHANI SINGH**



GETTY IMAGES

1 VIRAT KOHLI **43.7%** [23.9%]



AP

1 P.V. SINDHU **21.6%** [30%]

All it took was Virat Kohli to return to his century-scoring ways. The ace batsman scored his first ODI hundred in over three years against Bangladesh in December 2022 and returned to pole position in INDIA TODAY's Mood of the Nation poll as India's top sportsperson. With his bad form behind him and the inordinate pressure of leading the Indian team off his shoulders, Kohli can now focus on the job at hand—to play match-winning innings. The most followed Indian on Instagram—a whopping 233 million—is, unsurprisingly, back to being the most beloved sportsperson. India's obsession with cricket is reflected here, with three more cricketers, all batsmen, featuring in the top five sportspersons. Long retired from international cricket, M.S. Dhoni still holds sway over the nation, finishing second, followed by Rohit Sharma and the new superstar of white ball cricket, Suryakumar Yadav, a new entrant. Reigning Olympic champion Neeraj Chopra, who won the Diamond League finals and a silver medal at the World Athletics Championships, was the sole non-cricket athlete in the top five.

Among sportswomen, P.V. Sindhu, India's most successful shuttler ever, remains the one to beat. Finishing second was another retired cricketer, the inimitable Mithali Raj. Smriti Mandhana, the batswoman with the silken touch and captain Harmanpreet Kaur rounded off the list. ■

Q WHO DO YOU CONSIDER INDIA'S NO. 1 SPORTSPERSON?

MALE



2 M.S. DHONI **23.1%** [36.5%]



3 ROHIT SHARMA **6.5%** [9.5%]



4 SURYA KUMAR YADAV **6%**



5 NEERAJ CHOPRA **1.7%** [10%]

FEMALE



2 MITHALI RAJ **14.8%** [21.6%]



3 SMRITI MANDHANA **10.6%** [11.3%]



4 HARMAN-PREET KAUR **4.7%** [4.6%]



5 MIRABAI CHANU **4.5%** [11.8%]

Rest others; Jan. 2023 figs in bold; Aug. 2022 in brackets